PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Andersonville — A House Divided

Understanding Andersonville

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Andersonville — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Two habits at once: feel the human reality behind the numbers, and judge responsibility by the evidence — not by anger alone

THE SOURCES

SOURCE A · THE PHOTOGRAPH · AUGUST 1864 — The stockade, at its worst



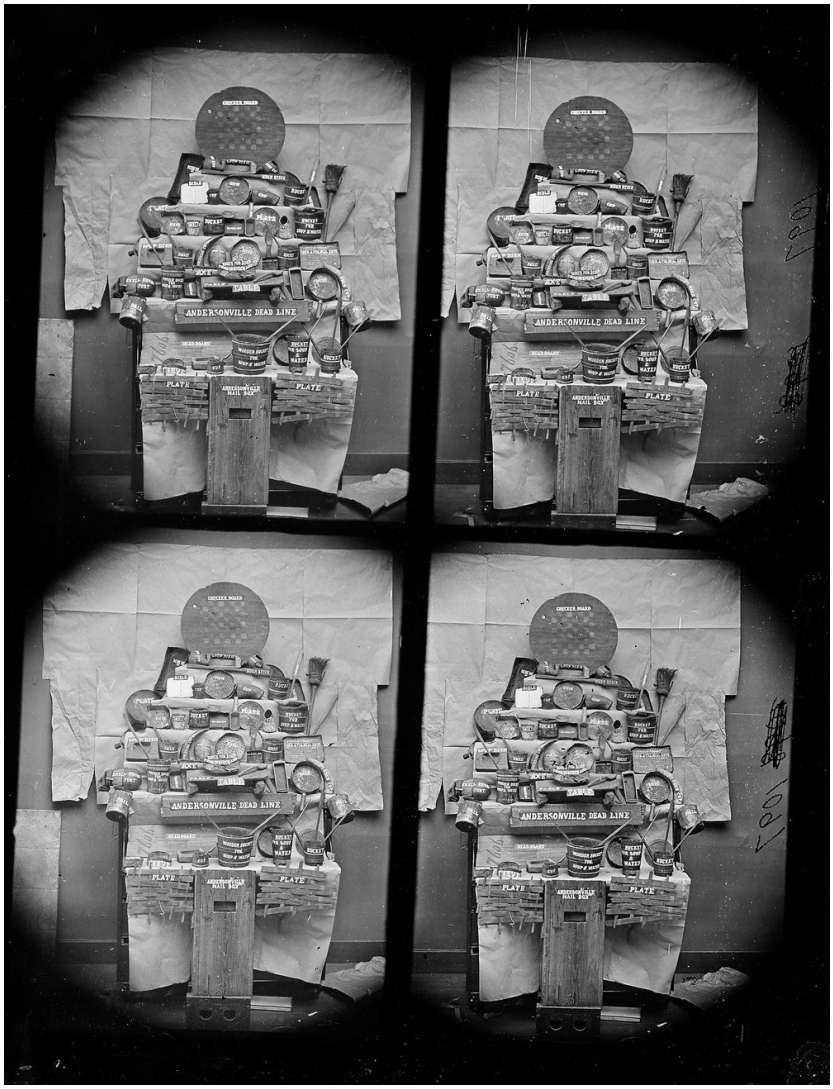
Andersonville Prison, Georgia — photograph by A. J. Riddle, August 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE B · A SURVIVOR'S TESTIMONY — Inside the fence

> *"There was no shade … no shelter from the burning sun or the drenching rain. … Men died at the rate of a hundred a day, and we buried them in long trenches, side by side."*
> *— account of an Andersonville survivor. Public domain*

— account of an Andersonville survivor. Public domain.

SOURCE C · RELICS, PHOTOGRAPHED LATER — The "Dead Line"



A line inside the fence marked the "dead line." Any prisoner who crossed it — even reaching for clean water — was shot by the guards

Relics of Andersonville — the "Dead Line" post and the prison mail box — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · HISTORICAL EMPATHY

Read Source B and study Source A together. In your own words, describe what daily life inside Andersonville was like. What did the men lack that they needed simply to survive?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · READ THE DATA

Of about 45,000 prisoners, nearly 13,000 died — close to a 29% death rate. Which statement best uses this number as evidence?

- ☐ A. it proves the camp was comfortable
- ☐ B. a death rate near one in three is powerful evidence of catastrophic, deadly conditions
- ☐ C. it proves no one really suffered
- ☐ D. numbers can never be used as evidence

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · ASSIGN RESPONSIBILITY

Historians debate who was to blame: the camp commander, the collapsing Confederacy that couldn't feed anyone, or the breakdown of prisoner exchanges on both sides. Weigh these explanations — which do you find most convincing, and what evidence would you want to decide?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

Mature historical thinking can hold two truths at once: a real atrocity happened, and its causes were complex. In two or three sentences, explain why it matters that we study Andersonville carefully instead of using it simply to paint one side as pure villains.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Andersonville — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Life inside the stockade was… The men lacked…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. a death rate near one in three is powerful evidence of catastrophic, deadly conditions**

Right. Nearly one in three men dying is overwhelming evidence of catastrophic conditions. A good historian lets the number establish the scale of the suffering before arguing about blame.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I find ___ most convincing because… To be sure, I would want evidence about…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Studying it carefully matters because…"